

PART 1

CYBERCRIME: THE PHENOMENON

Lesson 2 (C)

Cybercrime Typologies: Cyber-Assisted Crimes

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Cyber-assisted crimes: definition

- Traditional crimes in which the internet is used «to **assist with the organisation** of a crime» (Wall, 2005)
- McGuire and Dowling (2013) proposed the use of the term «*cyber-assisted crime*»
- The **digital tool is not critical** to these forms of crime, «which would still take place if the internet was removed» (Wall, 2017)
- Technology is part of more complex offences or criminal activities, used to **assist preexisting operations** or by moving part of their businesses online (Wall, 2017; Di Nicola, 2022)
- **Cyber-assisted forms of organization** (Wall, 2017)

Crime scripts

- Interdependent chains of crimes that are facilitated by the use of computers, computer networks and other forms of ICT (Di Nicola, 2022)
- The influence of the digital society is limited to one or more phases of the criminal activity
- Application of the concept of **crime scripts** (Cornish, 1994) to understand criminal processes and identify decision points
- The criminal activity can be «unfolded into separate but related phases» (Lavorgna, 2013)
- Cornish and Clarke (2002) recommended using this method to investigate organized crime
- Understanding the role of the Internet, the opportunities it creates and the phases in which they occur

Crime scripts: Tag writing

SCENE/FUNCTION	SCRIPT ACTION	SITUATIONAL CONTROL
PREPARATION	Buy spray-can Find a good setting	Sales regulation City paint-out program
ENTRY	Enter setting	Access control Entry / exit screening
PRE-CONDITION	Loiter	Surveillance
INSTRUMENTAL PRE-CONDITION	Select target	Remove target
INSTRUMENTAL INITIATION	Approach target	Surveillance
INSTRUMENTAL ACTUALIZATION	Reach target	Protective Screens Legal target provided
DOING	Spray graffiti	Graffiti-resistant paint
POST-CONDITION	Get away quietly	Moisture activated alarm
EXIT	Leave setting	Entry / exit screening
DOING (later)	“Getting up”	Rapid cleaning

Source: Cornish (1994: 165)

Crime scripts: Wildlife trafficking (I)

- Multi-stage crime and smuggling operation, which encompasses numerous activities (Wyatt, 2022)
- Various stages and phases
- The internet plays a crucial role in the advertising and selling stages of the illegal wildlife trade
- Easier to find potential buyers or sellers online (Lavorgna, 2020)
- **Wildlife crime linked to the internet**

Research | [Open access](#) | [Published: 15 May 2014](#)

Wildlife trafficking in the Internet age

[Anita Lavorgna](#) 

Crime Science 3, Article number: 5 (2014) | [Cite this article](#)

19k Accesses | 96 Citations | 13 Altmetric | [Metrics](#)

Coalition to End Wildlife Trafficking Online

Wildlife crime linked to the Internet

African online platforms must take urgent action to address illegal wildlife trade say experts

Crime scripts: Wildlife trafficking (II)

Stage 0: preparatory activities antecedent to the commission of wildlife trafficking

Stage 1: poaching, harvesting, or breeding of the animal/plant

Stage 2: intermediate passage through local middlemen/the domestic market

Stage 3: passage through a regional middlemen/international traders

Stage 4: intermediate passage through local middlemen/the domestic market

Stage 5: distribution of the animal/plant/product

Stage 6: activities that are directly consequential or subsequent to the trafficking activity

Crime scripts: Wildlife trafficking (III)

STAGE	FUNCTION	SCRIPT CATEGORY	ACTION IN WHICH THE INTERNET HAS BEEN USED
0	Preparation	Lifestyle Network	Formation/ existence of a criminal network (email, dedicated forums)
1	Preparation	Crime	Buy traps and other instruments to poach animals (commercial websites, dedicated forums)
1 and 4	Preparation	Crime	Use of Google translator to post announcements in different languages
0	Preparation	Crime Lifestyle	Discussion with other members of the criminal network about the existing relevant legislation (email)
0	Entry	Crime Lifestyle Network	Discussion with criminal peers in order to exchange information on new potential buyers (email)
1 and 4	Entry	Crime Lifestyle Network	Interaction with potential buyers (auction websites, generalist commercial websites, dedicated commercial websites, dedicated forums, reserved area in a website)
0	Precondition	Network Lifestyle	Maintenance of contacts with other members of the criminal network (email, Skype)
0	Precondition	Lifestyle Network	Signal species that have been recently discovered/that are more rare and valuable (dedicated websites)
4	Precondition	Crime	Get information on specific species (on their morphology and on how to breed them)
2 and 4	Precondition	Crime	Get information on relevant legislation
1 and 4	Precondition	Network Lifestyle	Share information about the location of the animal/plant/product in its natural environment (dedicated blogs)
3 and 4	Instrumental precondition	Crime Network	Agreement to exclude local middlemen who hesitate due to fear of prosecution over illegal activities (email)
4	Instrumental precondition	Network Crime	Search for new suppliers (emails, dedicated forums)
4	Instrumental precondition	Lifestyle Network	Inform potential clients/middlemen on updated prices (emails)

STAGE	FUNCTION	SCRIPT CATEGORY	ACTION IN WHICH THE INTERNET HAS BEEN USED
4	Instrumental precondition	Lifestyle Network	Advertising fairs and exhibitions (dedicated websites, dedicated forums)
4	Instrumental initiation	Lifestyle Network	Forward emails from suppliers who can fulfill orders from potential customers (email)
0	Instrumental initiation	Crime	Identify the location of the animal/plant/product via GPS and web mapping services (e.g., Google Maps)
5	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Order/reserve a specific animal/plant/product (dedicated commercial websites, dedicated forums, email)
3 and 4	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Advertise availability of new animals/plants/products (dedicated forums)
4	Instrumental actualization	Crime	Arrange sales of the animal/plant/product to final buyers (international auction websites)
1 and 3	Instrumental actualization	Crime Network	Arrange sales of the specimen to middlemen (international auction websites)
4 and 5	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Discuss prices/meeting places in the physical world to complete the deal (emails)
2, 3, and 4	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Discussion with other members of the criminal network about how to ship animal/plant/product in small packages with deceptive labels when sending them through regular mail (email)
4	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Agreement among criminal peers to physically meet and exchange animals/plants/products (private messaging in dedicated commercial websites, email)
4	Instrumental actualization	Crime Network	Put costumers directly in contact with middlemen or suppliers (emails)
4 and 5	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Contact directly consumers reassuring them that without documents the price is significantly lower (emails, dedicated forum)
4 and 5	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Discuss with potential customers the absence of required documentation (emails)
4 and 5	Instrumental actualization	Crime Lifestyle	Reassure customers about the quality of the animal/plant/product (dedicated commercial website, auction website)
1 and 4	Doing	Crime Lifestyle	Agreement to send animals/plants/products via regular mail among supplier and middlemen (emails)
1 and 4	Doing	Crime	Sell animals/plants/products on auction websites (e.g., eBay)

STAGE	FUNCTION	SCRIPT CATEGORY	ACTION IN WHICH THE INTERNET HAS BEEN USED
4	Doing	Crime	Automated sell of the animal/plant/product (order form on dedicated commercial website)
4, 5, and 6	Doing/post condition	Crime	Monitor the delivery via regular mail
4 and 5	Post condition	Crime	Payment (prepaid cards that can be recharged online)
6	Post condition	Lifestyle Network	Buy accessories/ share videos and pictures in cases of zoocrastry where wildlife animals are involved (dedicated forums, deep web)
4 and 6	Post condition	Crime Lifestyle	Attempt to cover the criminal act by claiming that animals/plants/products have been imported in the past with CITES certificates but they have been all given to others (dedicated website)

Source: Lavorgna (2013: 79-81)

New criminal opportunities

- Modern technological tools have created **new criminal opportunities** for organized groups (Lavorgna, 2013, 2015a ; 2015b)
- Five types of opportunities available to criminal groups:
 1. Opportunities for communication
 2. Management opportunities
 3. Organizational opportunities
 4. Relational opportunities
 5. Promotional, marketing, persuasive and fidelization opportunities
- Important to explore this area in order to better understand the impact of digital society on criminal activities (organized or not)

Cyber-assisted criminal activities



Trafficking activities of collectivities

- Counterfeit medicine trafficking
- Smuggling of migrants and asylum seekers
- Trafficking for the purpose of exploitation (particularly sexual)
- Terrorism or radicalization
- Sale of counterfeit products or psychotropic substances
- Illegal animal trafficking
- Tobacco trade



Criminal activities of individuals

- Using the internet to learn how to commit or hide a crime
- Using social media accounts to gather useful information about prospective victims
- Crime-as-a-service

Case study: Digital communications

- In 2020, dismantling of the encrypted communication tool EncroChat, used on a large scale by organized groups for criminal purposes
- Estimated 60,000 users
- Possible to intercept, share and analyse millions of communications
- Similar operations led to breaking up two encrypted communication networks: Ecclu and Sky ECC

New strike against encrypted criminal communications with dismantling of Exclu tool

Encrypted phone service 'Encrochat' shutdown leads to 6,500 arrests, Europol says

Dismantling encrypted criminal EncroChat communications leads to over 6 500 arrests and close to EUR 900 million seized

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Judiciary and police present first overview of results

Case study: Human trafficking

- Increasing importance of technology in the context of THB
- Two phases of human trafficking: **recruitment** and **exploitation** of victims
- Fake job advertisements: attractive work conditions lead to exploitative situations
- «Loverboy» method: the trafficker tries to establish a (fake) romantic relationship
- Hackathon 2023



Understanding the 'loverboy method' of human trafficking

How to spot fake job adverts

Targeted: human traffickers luring victims online

Case study: Illicit online markets

- Digital technologies can be used to facilitate the sale of illegal and contraband goods
- Counterfeit products
- Illegal dark web markets
- Wildlife and endangered species
- Cultural heritage artifacts
- Pharmaceuticals

288 dark web vendors arrested in major marketplace seizure

Law enforcement on three continents seize EUR 50.8 million in cash and virtual currencies, 850 kg of drugs and 117 firearms

International art trafficking operation leads to 60 arrests and over 11,000 objects recovered

International operation shuts down websites offering counterfeit goods and pirated content

12 526 websites taken down and 127 365 counterfeit products worth EUR 3.8 million seized

Inside the Dangerous Underground Abortion Pill Market Growing on Telegram

As states further limit access to abortion care in the US, a gray market for medication is filling the void. Buyers beware.